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The Advertising Psychology Playbook

THE PRINCIPLES BEHIND EVERY AD THAT ACTUALLY CONVERTS

WHY THIS MATTERS

Alright guys, this is where everything comes together. This might be the most important PDF you ever read.

Every framework, every script template, every hook formula you've learned in the AVB Ad Scriptwriting Frameworks playbook is built on top of a set of foundational principles. Those principles come from advertising psychology, and most of them were codified decades ago by people who spent millions of dollars figuring out what actually makes humans buy things.

The most referenced source in professional advertising is a book called Breakthrough Advertising by Eugene Schwartz, written in 1966. It's considered the advertising bible for a reason. The principles in it are not trends. They are not tactics. They are the underlying psychology that makes all advertising work, regardless of platform, era, or medium.

This playbook breaks down those principles in plain language with modern examples so you can apply them directly to every ad you create. Whether you're building AI-generated video ads, writing UGC scripts, or designing static creatives, these principles are what separate ads that convert from ads that get scrolled past.

Here's the thing. Tools change. Platforms change. AI models change. But human psychology doesn't. The person watching your ad in 2026 has the same brain, the same desires, and the same decision-making patterns as someone watching a TV commercial in 1966. If you understand the principles in this playbook, you'll be able to write effective ads on any platform, with any tool, for any product, forever.

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PRINCIPLE 1: MASS DESIRE

The Foundation of Every Profitable Ad

What It Is

At the most basic level, a business is just exchanging money for something. That something needs to be desired by people. Not just one person. Many people. That's what makes it scalable.

Mass desire is what happens when a private want becomes a public spread. A private want is something a person wants deep down. When enough people share that same want, it becomes mass desire.

Losing weight is a perfect example. Millions of people want to lose weight. Not all of them will admit it. But the desire is there, and it's massive.

The Most Important Rule

You cannot create desire. You can only capture it.

This is worth reading twice. You are not the government. You are not the news. You are an advertiser. You cannot make people want things. They already want them. Your job is to figure out what they want and get in front of it.

Think of desire like a river flowing in one direction. Your job as a marketer is to get in the middle of that flow. If your product and your ads follow the current, you're going to make money. If you try to fight it, you're going to struggle.

The Six Permanent Desires

Every human desire traces back to one of these six core drives. They have existed for as long as humans have been alive and they will never go away:

1. Health: The desire to feel good, look good, live longer, have energy
2. Sex / Attraction: The desire to be attractive, find a partner, be desired
3. Status: The desire to be respected, admired, seen as successful
4. Belonging: The desire to fit in, be part of a group, feel accepted
5. Control: The desire to have power over your life, decisions, and environment
6. Comfort: The desire for ease, relaxation, reduced stress and friction

When you go on Reddit, TikTok, or YouTube and find your target audience talking about what they want, every single one of those statements traces back to one of these six. Someone says "I want to be a better

parent." That could be status (they want to look like a good parent) or control (they want to feel like they have control over their household). Your research tells you which one it actually is.

How Desires Shift Over Time

The six desires are permanent, but the way they get fulfilled changes constantly in two ways:

1. Mass Education

When the world gets educated on something new, desire intensity changes. Health has always been a desire. But when a global health crisis hit in 2020, the desire for health spiked dramatically. People who never thought about their immune system suddenly cared deeply.

2. Style Trends

Status has existed forever. But status in the 1960s was having a cool car and being the known guy around town. Status in 2026 is social media followers and visible wealth. The desire didn't change. The vehicle for fulfilling it changed.

Real-World Examples

After 2020, there was massive distrust in pharmaceutical companies. The desire shifted toward natural remedies. Sea moss gel, shilajit, beetroot powder, pumpkin seed oil, all of it exploded. If you were selling sea moss in 2021, you didn't even have to be a good marketer. The desire was so strong it carried you. But trying to sell sea moss today? The desire has faded. It shifted. And that's the key. You have to research where desire is shifting to.

Same thing with comfort-focused brands. Companies selling comfortable loungewear did hundreds of millions when everyone was stuck at home. Comfort was a peak desire. But comfort isn't at the same intensity right now. Trying to launch the same product today wouldn't be nearly as easy.

How to Use This

Spot a desire on the uprise. Research what the world is wanting right now. What's that unfulfilled thing? What's changing? If you can catch a desire while it's still building momentum, that's where the real money is.

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APPLYING DESIRE TO YOUR ADS

One Ad, One Desire. That's the Rule.

After you find a product that fulfills a desire, the next step is understanding the strongest desire of the market for your specific target audience.

A single 35-year-old man and a married 35-year-old man both might want to solve hair loss. But the single guy might have a stronger desire to attract women. The married guy might have a stronger desire to feel young again. Those are two completely different ad angles even though the underlying desire (fixing their hair) is the same.

You need to know which desire is dominant for the specific avatar you're selling to.

The One-Desire Rule

Never appeal to multiple desires in a single ad.

If your ad is about attracting women at 35, do not also try to sell the desire of feeling young. Pick one desire and go all in on that.

One ad. One desire. That's the rule.

This is why the AVB Ad Scriptwriting Frameworks are built around single-message structure. Every framework, SPARK, MYTH KILLER, PRESSURE COOKER, all of them, they force you to pick one angle and commit to it. Multiple desires in one ad = diluted message = nobody feels like it was made for them.

How This Connects to Your Frameworks

When you're choosing which framework to use from the Ad Scriptwriting Frameworks playbook, start with the desire:

Health desire + problem aware audience = PRESSURE COOKER or SHORTCUT
Status desire + unaware audience = CLIFFHANGER or EDUCATOR
Comfort desire + solution aware audience = FACE-OFF or DEMO DROP
Belonging desire + any awareness = WITNESS or SPARK
Control desire + problem aware audience = MYTH KILLER or BRIDGE

The desire tells you WHAT to say. The framework tells you HOW to say it.

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PRINCIPLE 2: MARKET SOPHISTICATION

How Tired Is Your Market?

Market sophistication is basically a measure of saturation. The more competitors have sold to your audience before you, the more skeptical they get. The definition: how tired your market is of seeing products like yours.

There are five levels, and knowing where your market sits completely changes how you position your product.

Level 1: Brand New Category

Something completely groundbreaking. The first car. The first lightbulb. The first AI tool. At this level, you can literally just say what the product does and people buy it. Henry Ford could say "you can drive this without a horse" and that's all anyone needed to hear.

Realistically, you'll probably never be in a Level 1 market. They're extremely rare.

Level 2: Stronger Claims

You create a better version of what already exists. Once everyone has a lightbulb and everyone is saying the same thing, you stand out by saying yours shines brighter. You have a stronger claim.

Level 3: New Mechanism

Claims get old. Everyone's lightbulb shines bright now. So you introduce a new mechanism to solve the same problem. "This lightbulb uses LEDs." Now you're not competing on the same claim as everyone else. You've introduced something genuinely new. This creates real differentiation.

This is the sweet spot for most product launches. Look for products with new mechanisms.

Level 4: Better Mechanism

Everyone catches up to the new mechanism. Everyone has LEDs now. So you make a better version of that mechanism. "Our LEDs are 50 times brighter." "Our LEDs last 50 times longer."

The easy way to remember the difference: Level 2 emphasizes the claim. Level 4 emphasizes the mechanism.

Level 5: Identity Marketing

At level 5, nobody believes anything anymore. They've heard every claim. Brighter, faster, easier, longer lasting. All of it. At this point, people buy based on who they want to be, not what the product does.

Here's something interesting though. When a market hits Level 5, someone will often create a completely new mechanism and the market cycles back to Level 3. Then it matures to Level 4. Then back to Level 5. And the cycle repeats. Markets are always moving through these stages.

How to Find Your Market's Level

1. Analyze your product and find what's unique about it
2. Identify all competitors selling the same product and see what claims they're making
3. Identify indirect competitors solving the same problem differently
4. That gives you a clear picture of how sophisticated the market is

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PRINCIPLE 3: BELIEFS

The Invisible Gate Between Your Ad and a Sale

People only buy when they believe what you're saying. You can have the right desire, the right awareness level, the right product, and still get zero sales because your customer doesn't believe you.

Here's an example. If someone tried to sell something to an experienced marketer and their ad opened with "Facebook ads don't work in 2026," that marketer is done. They don't care what comes after that. That statement goes against what they believe to be true. The rest of the ad is dead.

The rule is simple:

You must accept beliefs as they exist, not as you wish they existed.

Do not try to change your customer's beliefs. It won't work. Your job is to either reinforce what they already believe or gradually shift them into a new belief that leads to a purchase.

And that "gradually" part is everything. Which brings us to the next principle.

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PRINCIPLE 4: GRADUALIZATION

Walk Them There One Step at a Time

Gradualization is how you actually implement belief shifting in your ads without losing people. It means walking the customer from what they already believe to what you need them to believe, one small step at a time.

If your ad opens with "lose 20 pounds in 30 days with this supplement" and that's it, nobody believes you. Their guard goes up immediately. They're gone.

But if you open with something they already agree with, something like "most diets fail because they starve you for two weeks before you snap," now you have a head nod. You have agreement. And from there you stack agreement on top of agreement until the big claim at the end feels like the obvious conclusion instead of a wild promise.

The Pattern

1. Start where they are (a belief they already hold)
2. Get a head nod (agreement on something obvious)
3. Stack another agreement (slightly more specific)
4. Stack another (introduces your angle)
5. Deliver the big claim (now it feels like the logical conclusion)

Bad ads open with the unbelievable promise. Good ads open where the customer already is and build from there.

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PRINCIPLE 5: INTENSIFICATION

Make Them Feel It So Strongly They Can't Say No

You've heard "sell the outcome, not the features." Intensification is that concept taken to its deepest level.

Wanting something a little doesn't make people buy. Wanting it badly does. Intensification takes a desire that already exists and cranks it up until the customer can't ignore it anymore.

The Rule

Don't sell them the benefit. Make them live in it!! This is super important.

A weak ad says "sleep better." A strong ad puts the customer in the morning after. It paints the picture of what their life actually looks like when the problem is solved.

Example:
Weak: "Our mattress helps you sleep better."
Strong: "Imagine waking up tomorrow and your back doesn't hurt. You don't reach for your phone to check the time at 3am. You just... wake up. Rested. Clear. Ready. Your partner notices it first. 'You seem different today.' You are different. Because for the first time in years, you actually slept."

Look at the difference. The second version makes you feel it. That feeling is what drives purchases, not feature lists, trust me.

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PRINCIPLE 6: IDENTIFICATION

People Buy Who It Makes Them, Not What It Does

Two products can do the exact same thing and one outsells the other 10 to 1 because it makes the customer feel like the type of person they want to be.

If you're selling a children's supplement, you're not selling health for their kids. You're selling the identity of being a good parent. A parent who actually takes care of their children.

If you're selling a fitness program, you're not selling workouts. You're selling the identity of being someone who has discipline. Someone who takes their health seriously.

Identity marketing is usually associated with Level 5 market sophistication (where claims have been exhausted), but honestly every ad should have a touch of it. Your entire ad and your entire landing page should reinforce an identity that your customer wants to have.

How to Apply It

Research who your customer actually wants to become, then frame your product as the bridge to get there.

Ask yourself: "When someone buys this product, what kind of person do they see themselves becoming?"

That answer is your identity angle.

The ORIGIN STORY framework (B.U.I.L.T.) is pure identification. The founder IS the identity. Viewers see themselves in the founder's journey and think "if they could do it, so could I." The SPARK framework (S.P.A.R.K.) also uses identification by showing the viewer that smart, successful people have already switched, making the viewer want to identify with that group.

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PRINCIPLE 7: REDEFINITION

Kill Objections Before They Even Come Up

Every product has objections attached to it. Too expensive. Too good to be true. Too hard to use. If you don't kill those objections, they won't buy. No matter how good the rest of your ad is.

The weak way to handle a price objection is saying "it's worth it" or "premium materials." Nobody believes that.

The strong way is to redefine the comparison entirely.

Example:
A posture corrector costs $79. The customer thinks that's expensive for a stretchy strap.

But a chiropractor visit is $120 and you need to go back every two weeks. That's $240 a month. This one-time purchase of $79 replaces six months of visits.

Now $79 sounds like an absolute steal for them.

You're not arguing the price, you're changing what they're comparing it to. That's the key part of this method.

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PRINCIPLE 8: MECHANIZATION

Show Them HOW It Works So They Believe THAT It Works

You can't just make a claim. You need to show the engine behind it.

The customer has heard "works fast" and "actually delivers results" a thousand times. The how is what makes the what believable.

Supplements talk about ingredients and how those ingredients work in the body. Physical products demonstrate the mechanism in action. Software products show the dashboard, the workflow, the before and after. Whatever your product is, you need to explain why it works instead of just saying "this works."

Example:
Weak: "Our serum reduces wrinkles."
Strong: "Retinol accelerates cell turnover, which means your skin replaces damaged cells faster. Combined with hyaluronic acid, which holds 1,000 times its weight in water, the new cells stay plump and hydrated instead of drying out. That's why wrinkles fill in within 2 weeks instead of 2 months."

The second version gives the customer a mental model of HOW it works. That mental model creates belief. And belief creates purchases.

PRINCIPLE 9: CONCENTRATION

Destroy the Alternatives

Customers aren't choosing between your product and nothing. They're choosing between your product and 10 other ways to solve the same problem.

Concentration means you stop talking about how good your product is and start talking about why everything else they've tried has failed them.

Compare on cost. Compare on time. Compare on effort. Compare on results. Destroy the alternatives and position your product as the only smart option remaining.

Example:
Instead of: "Our teeth whitening strips work great."
Try: "Whitening toothpaste takes 6 months and you barely notice. In-office bleaching costs $500 and you can't eat for a day. UV trays are clunky and give you sensitivity for a week. These strips take 30 minutes, cost $35, and you see results tomorrow morning. There's a reason 40,000 people stopped doing it the hard way."

PRINCIPLE 10: CAMOUFLAGE

The Second They Realize It's an Ad, It's Dead

The only ads that work in 2026 are the ones that don't look like ads.

If it looks like an ad, it gets treated like one. If it looks like something they already trust, it gets consumed.

Full production commercials don't convert the way they used to. Your ad needs to look like the content people are already consuming on whatever platform they're on. That means matching the format, the energy, the visual style, and the pacing of native content.

Platform Camouflage

TikTok/Reels: Selfie-style, phone-shot, casual talking, trending audio
YouTube: Educational format, longer narrative, face-to-camera or screen recordings
Meta Feed: Photo with text underneath (looks like a friend's post), carousel format
Instagram Stories: Quick, casual, poll/question stickers, lo-fi feel

Why Camouflage Matters for Testing

When you're trying to implement all of the principles from this playbook, you need to test fast. You won't know which beliefs work in the beginning. You won't know which pain points hit hardest. You won't know which redefinition strategy converts. You need to test like crazy.

With simple native-looking content (like a casual photo with a text caption), you just write the ad and pair it with an image. No production needed. You can push out ad after ad and get the feedback loop you need to figure out what actually works.

And with the capabilities of AI now, you can make atleast 10 video ads a day. At AVB we make hundreds per week.

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PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

The Complete System

Here's how all 10 principles work together when you're building an ad:

Before You Write a Single Word

1. Mass Desire: What does this audience want deep down? Which of the six permanent desires does this product tap into?
2. Market Sophistication: How tired is this market? Are you making a new claim, introducing a mechanism, or selling identity?
3. Beliefs: What does this audience already believe to be true? What beliefs do you need to work WITH (not against)?

While You're Writing

4. Gradualization: Start where they are. Stack agreements. Build to your claim.
5. Intensification: Don't just name the benefit. Make them feel what life looks like after.
6. Identification: Frame the product as a bridge to who they want to become.
7. Redefinition: Pre-handle every objection by changing what they compare you to.
8. Mechanization: Show the how so they believe the what.
9. Concentration: Destroy the alternatives. Make yours the only smart choice.

When You're Producing

10. Camouflage: Make the ad look like the content people already consume on that platform.

The Quick Reference

MASS DESIRE: What do they want?
SOPHISTICATION: How tired is the market?
BELIEFS: What do they already believe?
GRADUALIZATION: Walk them from known to new
INTENSIFICATION: Crank up the desire
IDENTIFICATION: Sell who they become
REDEFINITION: Kill objections by changing the comparison
MECHANIZATION: Show how it works
CONCENTRATION: Destroy alternatives
CAMOUFLAGE: Make it look native

If you can internalize these principles, you'll be able to write effective ads on any platform, with any tool, for any product, forever. Like I said before, these principles are time proof. The frameworks from the AVB Ad Scriptwriting Frameworks playbook give you the structure. The AI Advertisement Workflow Checklist gives you the process. This playbook gives you the psychology that makes all of it work.

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